

the 1990s, the number of people in the world who are under 15 years of age has increased by 1.2 billion, from 1.1 billion in 1980 to 2.3 billion in 1999 (United Nations 2000). The number of children in the world is projected to increase to 3.2 billion by 2020 (United Nations 2000).

There is a growing awareness of the need to ensure that the needs of children are met, and that children are protected from abuse and neglect. The United Nations Convention on the Rights of the Child (1989) is the most widely ratified international treaty in the world, and it sets out the rights of children to be heard, to be protected, and to be provided with the best possible living conditions. The Convention has been ratified by 112 countries, and it is being implemented in many other countries.

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